debating whether to open channels with the Pashtun-speaking Taliban (and not the Arabic-speaking AQ), for Narayanan such links were an expedient tactic to gather intelligence and use it against Pakistan (the NDS had anyways been providing copious amounts of intelligence to India on anything related to Pakistan).[72] Under no circumstances did these links mean that India was reconsidering its partisan strategy in Afghanistan. If anything, Narayanan was convinced that not only would Pakistan hijack any reconciliation process, but Karzai's motivations were also considered highly dubious. Asking Hekmatyar and Mullah Omar to join the government for personal political survival promised further weakening of the Afghan state and polarising the polity along ethnic lines. Karzai's initiative had raised such an alarm in New Delhi that Narayanan was on a plane to Kabul within hours of Karzai's announcement.[73] In Kabul, the Afghan government fruitlessly tried convincing Narayanan that Karzai 'needed' to engage with the Taliban officially—and directly—if any progress was to be made.[74] In May 2008, Narayanan told David Mulford and a top US intelligence official that Karzai's outreach to Pashtun insurgents caused leaders of other ethnic hues to question their status in Afghanistan.[75] Karzai's 'consultations' with Hekmatyar, thus, were 'unwelcome' and any deal with the Taliban, Narayanan said, 'cannot be a Pashtun-only solution'.[76]

Throughout Narayanan's tenure as NSA, allegedly, India silently funneled unknown amounts of cash to anti-Pakistan Afghan groups.[77] Amrullah Saleh, the Panjsheri NDS chief made a formidable partner in facilitating such interactions. But Karzai's overtures to the Taliban, and the traumatic experiences of the various kidnappings and killings that had occurred over the years led both R&AW and MI operatives to test the waters with the Taliban. Rakesh Sood and his team had built friendly relations with all thirty-four provincial governors, nearly seventeen of whom were close to Hekmatyar.[78] Sood's successor, Jayant Prasad, not only continued cultivating these relations with Hekmatyar's associates, but also allowed Indian intelligence officers to develop informal links with the Afghan Taliban.[79] Karzai's openness to covertly engage with the Taliban made this process both easy and necessary for India (despite reconciliation being an emotive issue at home). Thus, between 2006 and early 2010 (when Narayanan retired and Karzai won the 2009 elections), India bolstered relations with its former UF allies in the